Soft Apocalypse 2026

The Amber Prize: Short Stories

Narrative Architecture: The winning piece will demonstrate a structural intelligence that earns every choice it makes, including the decision to open where it opens, to end where it ends, and to move through its material in the order it does. This applies equally to the lyric essay and the compressed short story. Structure is not decoration. The judges will read for whether the form of the piece is inseparable from its meaning.

Voice and Prose Precision: Every sentence in the winning piece will feel written, not typed. This means a writer who knows the difference between a comma and a dash and uses each for a reason. It means a sentence that cannot be paraphrased without losing something. The Amber Prize goes to prose with a specific gravity, writing that resists skimming because every line is doing something.

Characterisation and Interiority: For fiction and flash, the judges will look for characters who feel inhabited from the inside, not described from the outside. A character the writer has lived with long enough to know their silences, not just their actions. For essays and hybrid work, this translates to a narrator whose intelligence and specificity make the piece irreplaceable.

Intellectual and Emotional Range: The winning prose piece will operate on more than one frequency simultaneously. It will think and feel at the same time. The judges are not looking for emotional writing that avoids ideas, or intellectual writing that avoids sensation. They are looking for work that holds both without collapsing into either.

The Discipline to End: This is rarer than it sounds. The Amber Prize will not go to a piece that earns its beginning and then loses its nerve. The final paragraph, the final sentence, will be as precise and intentional as the first. The reader will know, at the last line, that the piece is complete, not because it has explained itself, but because it has done what it came to do.

Best Regards,
Soft Apocalypse Team.